Hipster’s Quarterly Performance Review Framework Guidebook

Effective: August 2025

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1. Purpose and Context

As part of our broader organizational changes and our commitment to building a high-performance, high-accountability culture, we are introducing a formal Performance Review Framework.

This is not a one-off exercise, nor a bureaucratic box-ticking process. It is a core part of how we manage, grow, and reward talent in the company. We want every team member to know where they stand, what they are doing well, where they can improve, and how the company will support their development.

Our goals are to:

- Identify and reward strong performers
- Offer structured and fair support to those who are struggling
- Promote a culture of ownership, clarity, and open communication
- Build a transparent system for professional growth

2. Review Schedule

Two formal company-wide quarterly review cycles will be conducted for the rest of the year:

- Cycle 1: September 2025
- Cycle 2: December 2025

These reviews will be complemented by informal monthly check-ins and feedback touchpoints, particularly within active projects or when early signals need to be addressed before formal review cycles.

2.1. Monthly Check-Ins

To complement our formal quarterly reviews, monthly check-ins will be conducted to ensure ongoing visibility into individual progress, surface any early concerns, and strengthen the feedback loop between team members and their immediate leads.

These check-ins are intentionally informal and lightweight, serving as a mechanism to maintain clarity and momentum, especially for employees operating across multiple projects or dynamic timelines. However, they are **not optional**. All Team Leads and PMs are expected to conduct them regularly and report back.

Objective of Monthly Check-ins

- Facilitate early-stage course correction if issues arise
- Maintain alignment on expectations and workload
- Encourage two-way feedback and raise roadblocks in real time
- Track progress on informal goals or support provided

Check-ins are not used for scoring or official evaluation but act as a sustained touchpoint to monitor performance health between the formal reviews.

Who Conducts the Check-ins

- Team Leads and/or Project Managers (PMs) will initiate and conduct monthly check-ins based on who has the most day-to-day oversight of the employee.
- If an employee is active on multiple teams or projects, they will have separate check-ins with each lead or PM responsible for that respective project.
    - This ensures each project's context, contribution, and dynamics are properly addressed.
    - Leads and PMs are not expected to consolidate performance across unrelated workstreams. Employees should therefore expect to participate in more than one check-in per month if they are supporting more than one active project or functional team.
- For individuals under a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP), these check-ins will be more structured and tracked, with support from management where appropriate.

Format and Frequency

- Timing: Conducted once every month, ideally mid-cycle or aligned with internal sprint reviews
- Duration: 30-60 minutes
- Format: Team-wide meeting or 1:1 meeting via call or in person depending on the team's working arrangement
- Documentation:
    - While no formal scoring is required, Team Leads and PMs must submit a brief email report to management after each check-in, summarizing:
        - Key updates
        - Any concerns or support needed
        - Notable progress or follow-up points
    - These reports should be saved in the designated folder for centralized tracking and future reference during quarterly reviews or performance interventions.

Topics Covered

Each check-in will be adapted to the employee's current work but may include:

- General workload status and immediate priorities
- Team or cross-functional dynamics
- Blockers, delays, or recurring challenges
- Any recent feedback or behavioral observations worth discussing
- Clarification of expectations or shifting responsibilities

The emphasis is on support, not judgment. These conversations should be candid but respectful, and focused on enabling better outcomes moving forward.

Escalation and Next Steps

If serious concerns emerge during a check-in — such as repeated missed deliverables, communication breakdown, or disengagement — the lead or PM should:

- Raise the issue with management for support
- Share context, including prior feedback or related project factors
- Discuss whether further intervention (such as structured development goals or a PIP) is warranted

Monthly check-ins also serve as an early alert mechanism. When used consistently, they allow us to avoid surprises during formal reviews and ensure our team has the ongoing support needed to perform and grow.

3. Quarterly Review Rollout Process

Stage 1: Management and Team Lead Briefing

Week of [Insert Date]

A closed session will be held with team leads and project managers. This will cover:

- Detailed walkthrough of the review structure and expectations
- How to evaluate team members fairly and contextually
- How to conduct feedback conversations (especially for Band 1 and 2 ratings)
- Common biases to avoid (e.g., halo effect, rating inflation to avoid conflict)

- What support is available for those struggling to manage these conversations

Stage 2: Company-Wide Briefing

Week of [Insert Date] (Following the Management Briefing)

This will include all employees and will focus on:

- The purpose of the framework
- What the ratings mean
- What support systems are in place for development
- What happens if you're performing well — or falling short

Stage 3: Team-Level Rollout

Week of [Insert Date]

Each Team Lead will:

- Host a team meeting to explain how the review process applies to their team
- Conduct 1:1 sessions to share early feedback, clarify expectations, and offer a safe space for concerns

4. Applicability in Multi-Project Context

Because most of our employees work across multiple concurrent projects, reviews will:

- Evaluate team members per project
- Consider the weight of their contribution based on project complexity, duration, and scope
- Recognize that performance may vary depending on the project stage (maintenance vs. active feature development)

Final evaluations will be contextualized — we will not strongly penalize someone who scores lower on a small, poorly scoped project if they demonstrate strong performance elsewhere.

4.1. Reporting Lines and Responsibilities

Performance reviews will follow the official reporting structure defined in the organizational chart below, which should be kept updated ahead of each review cycle.

Insert updated organizational chart here.

While Hipster operates with clearly defined functional teams, we acknowledge that project assignments are fluid, and employees may support multiple projects simultaneously.

To maintain fairness and consistency:

- Each employee will be evaluated by the Team Lead or Project Manager (PM) who has direct operational oversight — typically the individual responsible for assigning tasks, managing timelines, and monitoring quality.
- Employees supporting multiple workstreams will receive distinct ratings for each project, as outlined in Section 7.
- Reviewers are only accountable for individuals formally under their line of oversight. Collaboration alone does not constitute review responsibility.

Before each review cycle:

- Leads and PMs must confirm their assigned reviewees.
- Any changes to reporting lines must be communicated to Amanda and Sandy.
- Reviewer assignments should be clearly documented in shared tracking tools to avoid ambiguity.

This structure ensures that while project assignments may shift, review ownership remains transparent and anchored in formal accountability.

Management Team

For clarity, the following individuals are designated as the management team in the organization chart:

- Amanda Han
- Sandy Yeo
- Nikhil Gupta
- Renendra Saxena
- Abhishek Kumar

They will collectively review and calibrate leadership performance, oversee score normalization where needed, and provide oversight to ensure the integrity of the process.

5. Performance Rating Bands + Feedback Format

We use a 5-point rating scale across all reviews. Each number has clear behavioral expectations, and corresponding organizational consequences. These are not relative scores — all team members could be a 4 or 5 if they meet the criteria.

	Description	What it Means
Band 5	● Exceeds expectations in all areas ● Shows initiative, leadership, and proactive problem-solving ● Anticipates blockers and solves them independently ● Mentors others and contributes to improving team performance ● Demonstrates strategic thinking and delivers high-value outcomes	● Strong candidate for promotion, bonuses, or leadership roles ● Prioritized for international or strategic opportunities (e.g., Singapore) ● May be asked to lead initiatives, guide peers, or represent the company externally
Band 4	● Above-average performance with high reliability ● Consistently delivers well within timelines and requirements ● Needs minimal supervision ● Communicates clearly and contributes to a positive team culture ● Often takes on more than assigned without complaint	● Eligible for performance bonuses and recognition ● Considered for expanded responsibilities or cross-functional growth ● Should be retained and nurtured as a long-term contributor
Band 3	● Solid and dependable contributor ● Meets expectations but rarely exceeds them ● Needs occasional guidance or reminders but delivers on time ● May not take initiative or ownership beyond assigned tasks	● This is the average standard; it is acceptable but not promotable ● No disciplinary action is taken ● Encouraged to take more ownership and develop additional competencies

	• May lack visibility, impact, or a proactive presence	• If consistently rated Band 3, the employee is viewed as stable but not on a leadership track
Band 2	• Inconsistent performance; completes some tasks but not reliably • Often requires guidance, may cause delays or rework • Lacks ownership and may need micromanagement • Misses deadlines or makes frequent errors • Poor communication habits (e.g., silence on blockers, poor documentation)	• Flagged for improvement • Will be placed on a Performance Improvement Plan (*PIP*) • If performance does not improve by the next cycle, employee will likely be phased out or reassigned • Coaching and structured goals will be applied to assist recovery
Band 1	• Fails to meet even minimum expectations • Work quality is low, deadlines are missed repeatedly • May show disengagement, absenteeism, or unprofessional conduct • Often shifts responsibility or blames others • Negatively affects team morale or client perception	• Immediate intervention is needed • Will be placed on a *PIP* with strict KPIs • High likelihood of termination if no meaningful progress is shown in the next cycle

Feedback Format

Role	Band	Contributions for the last 3 months	Feedback/ Improvement Area
Project Associate	Band 4	• Consistently delivered key projects on or ahead of schedule, with strong attention to detail and minimal need for oversight. • Helped to upsell Client X, helping the company earn an additional 40K. • Proactively took on additional responsibilities, including supporting adjacent teams during peak workload periods. • Played a key role in improving internal workflows by identifying inefficiencies and proposing actionable solutions. • Demonstrated high reliability and accountability, becoming a go-to team member for urgent or complex tasks.	• Leadership Readiness: Continue building leadership presence by mentoring the 3 junior team members or facilitating internal knowledge-sharing sessions. • Strategic Thinking: While execution is strong, developing a more strategic perspective (e.g. understanding broader business impact) would prepare you for more cross-functional growth. • **English Communication:** Improve English proficiency to communicate more effectively with both the team and clients. • Planning leaves ahead of time, and taking less urgent leaves.

6. Staff Feedback and Escalation Policy

During this performance review period, staff will also have the opportunity to flag project-level, team-level, or leadership-related concerns to upper management. This is to ensure systemic issues and leadership blind spots are surfaced constructively.

To maintain professionalism and preserve the integrity of team hierarchies:

- Team members may not rate or formally evaluate their Team Leads or PMs.
- However, they can provide **anonymous** specific feedback and documented examples of concerns or friction points they've experienced.
- Only objective feedback (not personal opinions or vague comments) will be considered for internal evaluation.

Feedback will be reviewed by Amanda and Sandy as the primary escalation points, with support from Nikhil, Renendra, and Abhishek as needed. Management will triangulate feedback through a combination of:

- Direct observation (e.g. team meetings, calls)
- Review of project documentation and deliverables
- Sentiment gathered from multiple team members

This ensures a fair and balanced view of how leadership and project dynamics are functioning, while still preserving clear reporting structures and authority boundaries.

After-Project Reviews

Feedback will also be formally gathered after project delivery to understand performance at a team and structural level.

- Large Projects: Feedback will be gathered at multiple phases (e.g. post-MVP, pre-handover)
- Small Projects: Feedback will be gathered post-delivery in one round

These reviews allow team members to:

- Surface issues related to team collaboration, scope clarity, resourcing, or project hygiene
- Raise concerns about project direction, feasibility, or leadership efficiency

Where applicable, this feedback may inform the performance review of the PM, alongside client satisfaction, delivery timelines, documentation quality, and ability to manage scope or conflict effectively.

7. Score Aggregation and Interpretation

Each employee will receive multiple project-specific ratings based on their involvement. Final evaluations are averaged, but not blindly.

How We Evaluate:

- If average score is 3 or above → No further review needed. Employee is in good standing.
- If average score is below 3 → HR/management will conduct a deeper review, including:
    - Time and weight of involvement across projects
    - Context for poor ratings (e.g., scope mismatch, poor client, resourcing issues)
    - Leadership feedback and behavioral examples

We will apply weighted averaging if needed:

- Projects with higher contribution or time allocation will carry more weight
- Strong performance on a large project may offset weaker performance on minor engagements

**However, any employee who receives a Band 1 or 2 rating in any project will be flagged, regardless of their average. A single serious performance concern will be reviewed immediately.*

8. Example: Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)

Employee: Nina Koh

Role: Backend Developer

Band Score: 2 (Fair)

Summary of Concerns:

- Missed 3 deadlines in past sprint cycle
- Did not inform team of unplanned leave; failed to attend 2 daily stand-ups
- Required support from others to complete assigned tickets
- Low responsiveness during QA/UAT phase

PIP Duration: 60-90 Days

PIP Goals and KPIs (To be drafted by Team Leads/ PMs/ Management)

Focus Area	Expectation	KPI
Timeliness	Complete work within agreed deadlines	100% task delivery within sprint
Communication	Daily check-in on Slack or stand-up	Minimum 5 updates/week

Ownership	Independently deliver 1 module without prompting	1 module with minimal feedback
Responsiveness	Timely replies to QA and lead messages	Response within 4 hours
Quality of Work	Submit code that passes initial QA	Max 2 rounds of agreed-on revisions per ticket

Check-Ins:

- Weekly 1:1s with Team Lead
- Midpoint check at Day 15
- Final review at Day 30

Possible Outcomes:

- Meets KPIs → Return to Band 3 or higher
- Fails KPIs → Possible extension or exit pathway triggered

9. Timeline and Next Steps

Date	**Milestone**
[Insert Date]	Team Lead & PM Briefing
[Insert Date]	Full Team Briefing

[Insert Date]	Team-level meetings and 1:1s
September 2025	Performance Review Cycle 1
December 2025	Performance Review Cycle 2

10. Support Contacts

For any questions, feedback, or clarifications, please reach out to Amanda and Sandy as the primary contacts.

11. Final Notes

This framework is a living process. As we grow, the structure may evolve, but the principles remain: clarity, fairness, accountability, and growth.

If you have suggestions on improving this framework, feel free to surface them. Let’s build a culture where expectations are clear, feedback is respected, and good work is rewarded.